

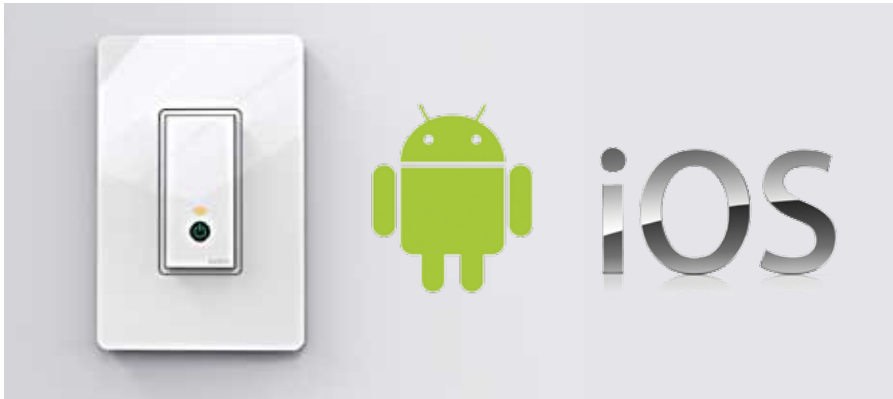
Google Glass news

Google's augmented reality based Project Glass may feature a laser-projected virtual keyboard to allow users to provide an input by tapping their hand or arm



Fake music views removed

YouTube, dropped 2 billion music views faked by record companies on their sites. This affected pageviews of certain celebrity videos



Belkin WeMo light switches are Wi-Fi enabled, fully controlled via iOS and Android apps

fertilizer levels. It beams this info over bluetooth to an app which helps monitor the health of plants in the sensor's vicinity.

A curious example of the impending convergence of technology and convenience is the Samsung T9000 refrigerator which runs on Android. Fitted with a Wi-Fi enabled 10-inch touchscreen panel, this smart fridge can help you with food recipes, regulate its temperature and features through the touch panel, take notes through Evernote, and much more. The Internet is no longer restricted to traditional computing devices (PC, smartphone, tablet), but household appliances like Wi-Fi lightbulbs, self-heating ovens (LG Smart Oven), self-regulating motion-detecting and temperature sensors, are just some of the examples showcased at this year's CES through which the concept of a smart home full of connected devices finally becomes a reality. The possibilities are endless.

Fuelling the advent of this Internet of connected devices are several trends. At a fundamental level, the Internet's switch to IPv6 ensures there is no shortage of IP addresses for devices willing to connect – the more the merrier! Broadband proliferation, reduction of data charges, and improved hardware (CPU, circuits, etc) is lending hitherto analog devices some semblance of "smartness" and digital awareness.

Beyond the hype

While it's great that we're pushing the spotlight away from the likes of smartphones and tablets – high-growth industry segments that have hogged all

the limelight in recent memory – and focusing on the impending boom of connected devices, the Internet of Things will be severely weakened if it ends up being just another cluster of devices. That won't be truly revolutionary, as there are several challenges yet to overcome.

Experience is a critical factor that will help take the Internet of Things to the next level. Take for e.g. the TV industry, which harped the horn of 3D TVs at CES 2010, and unveiled 4K Ultra HDTVs at this year's CES. Instead of just upgrading the visual experience, TV manufacturers should have put more thought on how to make these idiot boxes more smarter than



This ingenious plant sensor can help you monitor your garden through a smartphone

just recognizing gestures, dynamic picture control, and secondary PCs. A device's smartness or processing power (wow factor, in other words) won't be a limiting factor in realizing the full potential of connected devices, but the ecosystems that they plug into most certainly will be.

A smart fridge that can't automatically alert you about depleting inventory while you're on the road back home isn't smart enough; a sensor inside the garden soil isn't fulfilling its potential if it can't water the plant on its own (for e.g.); a fitness tracker that merely tracks burnt calories isn't good enough if it can't inform on calories consumed or recommending the right personalized diet. So the Internet they plug into needs to be smarter by deploying an accompanying service that they utilize. These services will also drive the end user experience and monetization models for companies to make the Internet of Things a sustainable business in the long run.

The Internet of Things will be multi-layered, in all probability. Imagine your car to be part of a home network where it's just another fully-automated gadget in your control. But if you step out on the road, there may be an Internet of Road Transport that it hooks into for route navigation, self-driving, etc., and this separate network will monitor and control all cars that are on the road. This may sound like science fiction, but a self-driving car is far from it. Also, what happens to all the connected devices leveraging the Internet of Things when there's a power failure and broadband's down? Scary to imagine that all your smart devices become dumb just like that, losing all their intelligence when they're offline. Sure there'll be workarounds developed to counter this challenge as well.

The Internet is evolving and it's no longer a place where you only go to find information, it's now a place where you go to find things and objects. This trend will only continue to unravel and grow in the coming months or so, where manufacturers realise and push the envelop of our imagination, making us view the Internet through a new lens. The Internet of Things is arriving fast and there's no stopping it. Did we say, Internet? Behold, the Thingternet!